THE VILLAGE VANGUARD

Breaking patriarchal barriers, these women sarpanches have transformed rural India. Their inspiring leadership showcases how grassroots governance empowers communities and sets benchmarks for inclusive development

» Arati Devi Ganjam, Odisha
An ex-investment banker, she initiated literacy campaigns, revived folk art, improved the public distribution system. Was the first Indian to be invited to the US International Leadership Program for governance transparency

» Shahnaaz Khan
Garhazan, Haryana
An MBBS student, she inspired girls' education and sanitation improvements in the conservative Mewat region, bridging health and education gaps

» Chhavi Rajawat
Soda, Rajasthan
This MBA graduate has worked on improving water access, roads, solar energy, banking and sanitation. Addressed UN Poverty Conference, symbolising young India's vision for rural transformation

» Meenakshi Gadge
Mukhra (K), Telangana
Enforced liquor ban, implemented eco projects like planting 100,000 trees, made village solar-powered. Honoured with multiple national awards for sustainable governance

» Meena Behen Vyara, Gujarat
The first woman sarpanch in Gujarat headed an all-women panchayat. Built roads, improved village access to government schemes, advocating education and social inclusion

» Radha Devi
Bhadsiya, Rajasthan
A Class 5 dropout herself, she increased school enrolment, reduced dropout rate via NGO collaboration. Confronted authorities to ensure RTE implementation


SPECIAL REPORTS

PANCHAYATI RAJ

From Doon to 'Dehat'

Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi's latest tinkering on the Panchayati Raj proposals has pale aim of the Government and the ruling party. But the timing of the move and its background suggest it has electoral connotations.

FROM THE ARCHIVES
May 31, 1989

Special report
From Doon to 'Dehat'

After four years of flipping and flopping, Rajiv Gandhi has found it impossible to shed his yuppie image. To many, especially the rural masses, his government has been seen as one with an urban orientation. Operation Panchayati Raj offers Rajiv and his party their last, and best chance to orchestrate a substantive change in image and mobilise the masses before the parliamentary elections.

–Prabhu Chawla

ing the backlash from the Shah Bano case and the Mandal Commission report, weakened Gandhi's political capital. His assassination in 1991 tragically cut short his reformist agenda.

It was his successor, P.V. Narasimha Rao, who navigated the legislation through a fractious Parliament. The 73rd Amendment Act was passed in December 1992, establishing PRIs as constitutional entities with provisions for a three-tier system, financial devolution, and reservations for Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and women. The Eleventh Schedule listed 29 functions to be devolved to PRIs, ranging from agriculture to public health and education. Simultaneously, the 74th Amendment Act redefined urban governance by mandating the formation of nagar panchayats, municipal councils and municipal corporations. These institutions were entrusted with planning and implementing development schemes, with the Twelfth Schedule listing 18 functions including urban planning, water supply and slum improvement.

When the Congress came back to power in 2004, a new panchayati raj ministry was created with Rajiv Gandhi's old confidant Mani Shankar Aiyar at its helm. He championed policies to further enhance financial and administrative powers of the PRIs as laid down in the 1992 amendments. Together, these amendments represent the zenith of democratic decentralisation. By embedding institutions like the State Election Commissions and State Finance Commissions, they ensured these bodies were not mere titular entities but vibrant instruments of governance. The PRIs and Nagar Palikas became platforms where marginalised voices could exert political agency. Today, more than a million women representatives play active roles in PRIs.

1.4 MILLION
Women serving as elected members of PRIs–46% of the total

Yet, these amendments are not without challenges. Financial devolution remains a stumbling block, with states reluctant to share adequate funds, functions and functionaries. Despite this, success stories abound—Kerala's holistic decentralisation model and Rajasthan's devolution experiments exemplify what can be achieved with political will and administrative resolve. This is what the architects of these amendments envisioned—bringing governance closer to the governed. ■